

Corytophanes cristatus

Helmeted iguana



Length 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

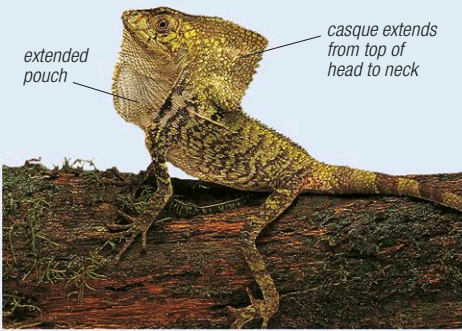
Location S. Mexico to N. South America



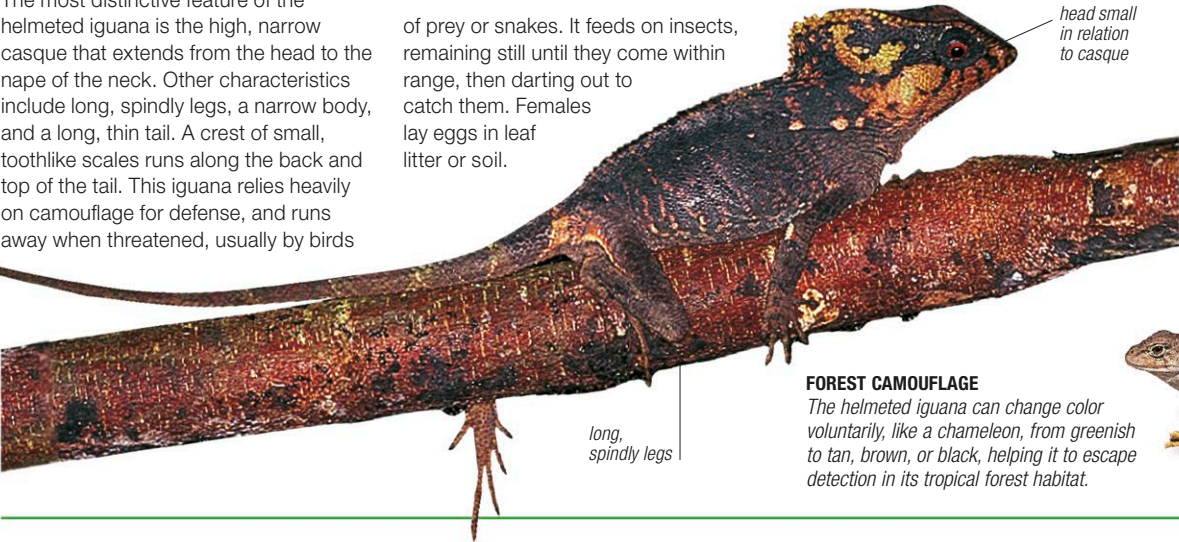
The most distinctive feature of the helmeted iguana is the high, narrow casque that extends from the head to the nape of the neck. Other characteristics include long, spindly legs, a narrow body, and a long, thin tail. A crest of small, toothlike scales runs along the back and top of the tail. This iguana relies heavily on camouflage for defense, and runs away when threatened, usually by birds

KEY FEATURES

The high, narrow casque on the head distinguishes this iguana from all other lizards in tropical America; the precise function of this casque, or “helmet,” is unknown. When this iguana is defending its territory, it extends the pouch under its head to ward off other animals.



of prey or snakes. It feeds on insects, remaining still until they come within range, then darting out to catch them. Females lay eggs in leaf litter or soil.



FOREST CAMOUFLAGE

The helmeted iguana can change color voluntarily, like a chameleon, from greenish to tan, brown, or black, helping it to escape detection in its tropical forest habitat.

Crotaphytus collaris

Collared lizard

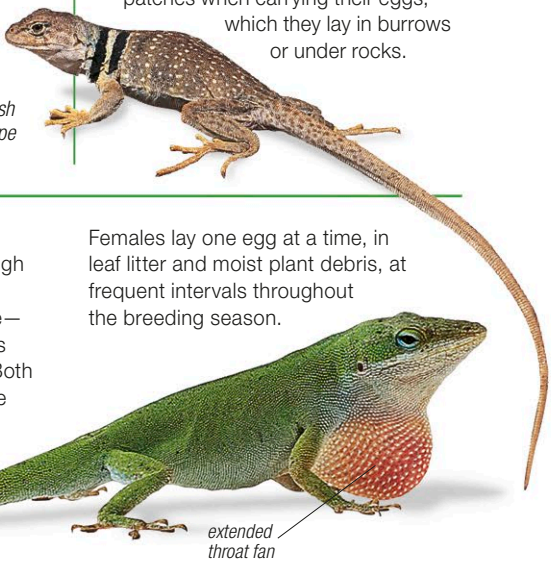


Length 8–14 in (20–35 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location C. and S. USA, N. Mexico



The brown or greenish brown collared lizard is distinguished by the black and white markings around its neck. It has long hind legs that enable it to flee rapidly from danger, often to retreat to a burrow or beneath a boulder; the front limbs may leave the ground entirely when it runs fast. Active only on hot days, this lizard perches on rocks looking for insects and smaller lizards. Its strong jaws can crush even large prey, and may also be used to bite in defense. Females develop orange patches when carrying their eggs, which they lay in burrows or under rocks.



Anolis carolinensis

Green anole



Length 4¼–8 in (12–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



Anole lizards are found only in the Americas. There are over 400 species, and most—including this one—are slender animals with long tails and legs, and distinctive display fans beneath their throats. Like many of its relatives, the green anole is a tree dweller, feeding mainly on insects. It sleeps in bushes at night, but during the day often basks on vertical surfaces such as palm fronds, tree trunks, fence posts, and walls,

staying in place with the help of expanded pads on its toes. Although normally bright green in color, it turns brown when it rests in shade—which explains why it is sometimes erroneously called a chameleon. Both sexes possess the pink, extendible throat fan. Males use theirs more often, signaling to rivals and potential mates.

Females lay one egg at a time, in leaf litter and moist plant debris, at frequent intervals throughout the breeding season.



Amblyrhynchus cristatus

Marine iguana



Length 20–39 in (50–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location Galapagos Islands



The marine iguana, with its large, scaly head and back, is the only lizard that forages for food in the sea. It dives for algae in the cold waters off the Galapagos Islands, and its body is specially adapted to cope with both cold and with excess salt. Large adults may dive down to 39 ft (12 m) and can stay underwater for over an hour, but under normal conditions they feed during shallow dives lasting less than 10 minutes. When not feeding, marine iguanas warm up by basking on rocks, and often several thousand can be seen

together on the same stretch of shore. During the breeding season, males fight aggressively for the opportunity to mate. Suitable nesting sites are scarce, so thousands of females often nest together,

laying 1–6 eggs in sandy burrows. After an incubation period of 2–3 months, the young emerge to feed in the intertidal zone and hide in rock crevices to escape attack from gulls and other seabirds.

VARYING NEIGHBORS

Marine iguanas often have a “whitewashed” look, which comes from salt expelled by their nasal glands. There is great variation in adult weight between islands: on Fernandina Island, males can be over 24 lb (11 kg), while on Genovesa, they rarely reach 2¼ lb (1 kg).



Conolophus marthae

Galapagos pink land iguana



Length 39 in (100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Critically endangered

Location Galapagos Islands



Described in 2009, this iguana is found only on Volcan Wolf on Isabela Island and possibly fewer than 100 individuals exist. DNA evidence suggests that it diverged from other Galapagos land iguanas around 5.7 million years ago.

